10
ECONOMIC RESPONSE

16 APRIL 2020

INDIA | 11,213 ACTIVE CASES | 449 DEATHS

WORLD | 14,83,234 ACTIVE CASES | 1,53,514 DEATHS

While India was preparing to exit lockdown in the upcoming weeks, the challenges staring us in the face were unprecedented. China had suffered a huge loss in credibility due to its failure to alert the world early on about the virus and its origins and its refusal to quarantine itself so that the world could be insulated. However, in an effort to build back some reputational positivity, it had begun to supply all kinds of medical equipment necessary to fight the virus to countries across the world. India too, like most other countries, relied on the Chinese to source PPE kits, rapid antigen testing kits, raw materials for medicines and several other necessary products.

However, reality hit us hard when we received lakhs of faulty testing kits and PPE kits. We were at a crucial intersection in our fight against COVID-19, we needed to scale up testing significantly and rapid testing kits would enable us to do just that. These kits were meant to produce results within 30 minutes and could be used by local governments to get an accurate idea of the scale of infection in a particular territory by deploying mass testing, i.e., sero-surveys. Sero surveillance would enable us to further break down the impact of the virus on specific demographics. At a time when India's unlocking strategy was based on classifying districts as red, yellow and green zones and further creating micro-containment zones in areas of high prevalence, rapid testing kits would be a boon. Various Indian states had been pushing the ICMR to allow testing with these kits amidst criticism that we were simply not testing enough. The ICMR was initially reluctant, since the result accuracy of rapid testing kits was much lower